Janaki Janmasthali Temple complex.

To let rest any lingering doubt, it will be modelled on Ayodhya's Ram temple, including parikrama paths, spiritual gardens, museums, dharamshalas, cultural spaces and a 67-acre religious corridor. The symbolism is as potent as its scale—Sita, the daughter of Mithila, having the added resonance of being seen as a native cultural emblem.

THE MITHILA MANOEUVRE

Mithila is a cultural-linguistic region where regional identity and faith are tightly braided in everyday life. Its core districts—Darbhanga, Madhubani, Muzaffarpur, Samastipur, Sitamarhi, Sheohar, Vaishali, Saharsa, Supaul, Madhepura—account for roughly 69 assembly seats, nearly 29 per cent of Bihar's total of 243. Here, a Sita temple serves as grand theatre that yokes devotion to development: the state frames the scheme as heritage-led growth. It holds the promise of improved road and rail links, hotel capacity, a place on the national pilgrimage circuit, and livelihoods. It's culture as currency.

Takeaways

- **Nitish launches the Janaki Janmasthali temple project at Sitamarhi, mirroring Ayodhya**
- **It offers Nitish a platform to tap into Hindutva sentiment ahead of the Bihar polls**

Institutionally, the state has sought to depoliticise the project by placing it under a trust headed by the chief secretary—here, the development commissioner and district magistrate will rub shoulders with religious representatives. That converts it into a public programme; operationally, it gives the government clearer mechanisms to move to land procurement, construction and tourism marketing. But that doesn't erase the political calculus. The promised benefits may take years to materialise, but elections demand immediacy. Hence, a stage for Nitish to attempt a sartorial change—a splash of saffron on a coat he has generally kept buttoned. ■

▶ GOA

ROOM FOR THE ORIGINAL GOANS

Goa's unheralded tribal communities see a long struggle for political reservations bear fruit

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IT WAS PROVING A TOUCH INJURIOUS for the BJP to be holding out, as it had for over a decade. Conversely, it was also deemed safe enough and advantageous to concede—the demographic patterns are such. Thus comes about a resolution to the long-pending Adivasi demand for political quotas in Goa.

The Parliament has approved a tongue-twister of a legislation—the Readjustment of Representation of Scheduled Tribes in Assembly Constituencies of the State of Goa Bill, 2024—to accomplish that. It awaits an enumeration by the census commissioner. Based on the population, the Election Commission will make amendments to the delimitation order to provide for the reservation of seats in the state assembly.

ONE IN TEN GOANS

Goa's tribals—acknowledged as descendants of the state's original inhabitants—are currently estimated to number about 149,275, including those of Christian denomination. That's a notable 10.23 per cent of Goa's population. This ratio was reached after the Gauda, Velip



HERITAGE BEATS Goan tribals celebrating their traditional festival at Cotigao, Canacona